the citizens' group, Bengaluru Political Action Committee, and independent director of the government-run Bengaluru Smart Infrastructure Ltd. "A recent review of the tech corridor along Outer Ring Road stretched from 10 pm to 2.30 am," Misra recounts. "He was unrelenting."

THE BIG CLEAN-UP

Garbage is where everyone started noticing. Believe it or not, Bengaluru deploys 5,100 autorickshaw-tippers to collect garbage door-to-door every day, but monitoring them is practically impossible because they lack GPS trackers. In a city that generates 5,800-6,000 tonnes of garbage daily, a lot of it was falling off the map. Or rather, piling up at the infamous 'black spots' that proliferated on street corners. Even the Lokayukta, pursuing civic agencies via suo motu cases and monthly hearings, struggled to shake up the lawless ad-hocism. Byre Gowda has now pressed reset. "For 20 years, we were unable to move with the times," he says, referring to a bizarre hold-up in the tendering process for garbage contracts. It's so notoriously difficult an exercise that Bengaluru last successfully concluded city-wide tenders for this back in 2005-06. Since then, entrenched interest groups thwarted every attempt at cohesion. Even DKS, as the minister earlier, often vented his frustration at the 'garbage mafia'. Late August, finally, saw action: the government approved 21 work packages, out of a total of 33 packages worth Rs 620 crore annually. The remaining 12, pertaining to one-third of Greater Bengaluru, are in various stages pending court directions. "This is the first time after 2006 that some tendering has reached a final stage. I'm confident we can make tangible improvement," notes Byre Gowda. The new fleet of three-tonne auto-tippers will have GPS tracking; they will also treble clearing capacity compared to the one-tonne vehicles in use. More collection, lesser trips.

The Big Bengaluru Clean-up, in fact, had started on the footpaths. A landmark Supreme Court ruling on June 19, declaring the citizen's right to walk on demarcated footpaths as a fundamental right, offered the impetus. On July 1, the new minister launched himself at the task with great gusto. This was a more complex issue, though. Street vendors were impacted, and there was resistance. Byre Gowda devised a formula to balance the competing imperatives. "We need to protect their livelihoods also. I'm leaving 80 per cent of the roads open to street vending," he said in an X post on July 9, explaining that the focus would be on freeing up pavements on arterial roads. By August 24, counting all fronts, Bengaluru had cleared 1,162 km of footpaths. Gone were 4,827 tonnes of debris, 6,798 advertisement pillars and boards, 4,405 steps and ramps, and 3,693 shops/petty shops. Parallelly, another drive extended waste removal to unused, vacant plots—140,277 tonnes of debris were cleared in one month.

The garbage pile-up was especially challenging due to Bengaluru's paltry record of waste segregation. Nearly half of what it disgorges daily is wet waste, and its supposed destinations are seven plants run by the Bengaluru Solid Waste Management Ltd (BSWML), an entity set up in 2021. But it's all mixed up with the other stuff, so the whole caboodle goes to a landfill. A year ago, Bengaluru tossed 4,000 tonnes of mixed waste at the landfill daily. But this problem met a head with a yen for sorting. BSWML says it enforced segregation, especially of low-value plastic: wrappers, sachets and the like. The landfill numbers have progressively been whittled down to about 2,600 tonnes. "We are going to drill down on segregation at source," says Byre Gowda.

> **"The idea of GBA needed a strong political leader at the helm, which Krishna Byre Gowda provides. Now, he has become the city's face in a certain sense"**
>
> **V. RAVICHANDAR,** *Urbanist; member, Brand Bengaluru Committee, which redrew the city's civic map*



BENGALURU 2037: A METROPOLIS REIMAGINED

The Master Plan for 2037, the 500th anniversary of Bengaluru's founding, is an ambitious economic roadmap to integrate the entire metropolitan region, a vast 8,000 sq. km area across three districts, with the city as its beating heart. The key idea is to make the IT City future-ready for the 21st century while decentralising its economy into satellite growth hubs so as to prevent hyper-congestion. The strategy spreads across deep-tech, knowledge services and advanced manufacturing

TARGET

- Grow the Bengaluru Metropolitan Region's economy to **$400 billion** (Rs 38 lakh crore) from $149 bn (Rs 14 lakh crore) today
- Add **2 to 2.5 million jobs** with focus on new-age sectors